



Wireless earphones or neckband-style earphones nestle between wired and truly wireless earphones, and are wildly popular as well. These buds offer the convenience of cord-free connectivity while still being less easy to misplace than TWS earphones. A lot of technological innovations that are seen in TWS earphones also trickle down to this category. In 2022, these included long battery life, supporting apps, Active Noise Cancellation, and more. However, in the budget wireless earphones category features such as ANC usually don't make their way on to the device. What you do get though, is a wide net of other features. This year, we even saw a bunch of budget wireless earphones come with over 100 hours of battery life! While high-end launches in this segment have dried up a bit, budget launches are still rampant. IWe thoroughly tested all the contenders and we've nailed down the winner.

Winner: Sony WI-C100

The Sony WI-C100 is a solid neckband-style wireless pair of earphones with a lot on offer despite its inexpensive price point. Packing 9 mm drivers, the Sony WI-C100 comes with the company's DSEE (Digital Sound Enhancement Engine) that digitally upscales compressed audio files. Turn this mode on in Sony's Headphone Connect app since it makes a considerable difference in the sound fidelity, especially if you listen to music on streaming platforms such as Spotify, YouTube Music, and others. The sound quality is well-balanced; the bass response packs a punch without sounding boomy, the mids are detailed, and the highs aren't tinny at all, which is a plus point. What's even more impressive is that the app has

DIGIT BEST BUY WINNER-2022



Noise Xtreme
Price: ₹1,599

a customisable EQ which is almost unheard of in other neckbands at this price point. Additionally, you also get solid battery life. We recorded about 25 hours of playback time in our testing, which is enough to last most users a few days with ease. The microphone is also pretty good and can be used indoors without any issues. Overall, these are a versatile pair of wireless earphones with fantastic sound quality for the price.

Budget Wireless Earphones

Pocket-friendly without compromising quality



Sony WI-C100
Price: Starting at ₹1,699

Runner-up and Best Buy: Noise Xtreme

The Noise Xtreme surprised us. We are used to Noise earphones having an overwhelmingly bass-boosted sound profile that can sometimes sour the listening experience, but the Xtreme convinced us that there are some gems in Noise's portfolio too. These earphones, while still bass-biased, have an enjoyable sound profile with lots of drive, energy and good fidelity. The bass response is punchy but the mids are overemphasised too which means they don't get too shrouded by the bass. The highs are sparkly as well, however, there is a sharp dip-off point which can be slightly jarring. Moving on to possibly the most impressive feature of the Noise Xtreme – the earphones come with a rated battery life of over 100 hours! Through our testing, we can confirm that this is the longest-lasting pair of wireless earphones we've tested. The earphones also come with an array of other features at an inexpensive price point making it a worthy runner-up and Best Buy winner.

– Dhriti Datta | dhriti@digit.in